

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Customer Success English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

03 Support Escalations and Incident Communication

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 QBRs and Business Outcomes

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Renewals and Churn Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

06 Expansion and Upsell Ethics

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

07 Product Feedback and Feature Requests

Clarify missing information before responding.

08 Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

onboarding - The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively.

go-live - The point at which a system or service begins its intended operational use.

implementation - Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation.

customer owner - The person on the customer's side responsible for coordinating an agreed activity.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - B. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - C. Could you confirm when starts the review?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - B. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - C. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Next Friday is an expectation, not a confirmed go-live

The lesson's customer expects go-live next Friday, while migration responsibilities and training dates remain unassigned.

01 • Customer success manager: You expect to go live next Friday. Could we clarify who owns migration and when training will take place?

02 • Customer project lead: Those responsibilities and dates haven't been assigned yet. I assumed implementation would handle them automatically.

03 • Customer success manager: We need explicit ownership before treating the date as confirmed. Which customer owner can coordinate the migration inputs?

04 • Customer project lead: I need to identify that person internally rather than assign the task to someone without checking.

05 • Customer success manager: Thank you. Training also needs agreed participants and timing; we shouldn't infer readiness from a target date.

06 • Customer project lead: Could we keep next Friday as an aspiration while making the outstanding dependencies visible?

07 • Customer success manager: Yes, clearly labeled as your target, not a confirmed go-live commitment from the implementation team.

08 • Customer project lead: I'll clarify the customer owner and bring available training times for discussion.

09 • Customer success manager: Then we'll review the onboarding dependencies together and assess a realistic plan using the confirmed information.

10 • Customer project lead: Agreed. I won't tell our users that launch is settled while those responsibilities remain open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Imported data or validated data?

Separate fictional case: a customer's onboarding tracker says data ready after an upload; the customer has not reviewed the imported records.

01 • Implementation manager: The tracker says data ready. Does that mean the upload finished, or that your team validated the imported records?

02 • Customer data owner: Only the upload is complete. We haven't reviewed the records in the new system yet.

03 • Implementation manager: Then let's clarify the label so nobody treats transfer completion as readiness for live use.

04 • Customer data owner: What do you need us to confirm before you can assess the remaining implementation steps?

05 • Implementation manager: We need the agreed validation outcome and any unresolved issues, using the project's actual acceptance process.

06 • Customer data owner: I can coordinate that review, but I don't yet know how long it will take.

07 • Implementation manager: Please confirm timing after checking capacity. I won't invent a go-live date based on an unreviewed upload.

08 • Customer data owner: Understood. I'll change our spoken status to uploaded, validation pending when I brief the project lead.

09 • Implementation manager: Good. Once you report the review result, we can discuss its impact on the onboarding plan.

10 • Customer data owner: I'll return with that result or clearly identified gaps, rather than call everything ready prematurely.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Administrator training or training for everyone?

Separate fictional case: a fictional onboarding plan lists one training session, but the customer expects both administrator and end-user instruction; audience scope is unconfirmed.

01 • Customer enablement lead: The plan lists one training session. Could you clarify whether that covers administrators, end users, or both?

02 • Customer success manager: The audience isn't specified, so I need to check the agreed onboarding scope before confirming coverage.

03 • Customer enablement lead: We assumed everyone would attend the same session, but administrators have different setup responsibilities.

04 • Customer success manager: That distinction matters. One calendar entry doesn't establish that both audiences' needs have been planned.

05 • Customer enablement lead: Could we identify what each group needs to do before selecting the session format?

06 • Customer success manager: Yes. Then we can assess the requirements against the implementation arrangement and flag any additional scope.

07 • Customer enablement lead: I can provide the audience roles, but I shouldn't promise separate sessions until you've checked availability and scope.

08 • Customer success manager: Correct. I'll clarify the intended training deliverable and what remains unresolved.

09 • Customer enablement lead: Let's keep the training date provisional until the audience and purpose are agreed.

10 • Customer success manager: Agreed. We'll confirm those details before using training scheduled as evidence of go-live readiness.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

Scenario 2 | A sandbox mistaken for the live environment

A fictional customer has received access to a sandbox with synthetic records and assumes it is the production environment. Production setup and launch timing are unconfirmed. Hold an onboarding clarification call.

Role A: You are the implementation manager. Clarify which environment was supplied and its intended use.

Role B: You are the customer project owner. Ask what remains before live use and avoid making a launch announcement.

Possible opening: The access provided is for a sandbox with synthetic records, not a confirmed production launch.

Success checks

- Distinguish practice access from production readiness.
- Clarify the customer owner's next questions without inventing completion dates.
- Agree the confirmation needed before live-use instructions are sent.

Add a complication: The customer wants to invite all users to start live work immediately.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

An account has many logins but little use of the workflow it purchased the product to improve.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

adoption - The extent to which people begin and continue using a product or process.

health score - A defined summary indicator used to assess the state of a customer account.

stakeholder engagement - The involvement and interaction of people affected by an activity or decision.

usage - Observed use of a product or service under a defined measurement.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - B. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - C. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - B. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - C. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Many logins, little workflow adoption

The lesson's account has frequent logins but limited use of the workflow the product was purchased to improve.

01 • Account director: The account has many logins. Why doesn't that establish strong adoption of the product?

02 • Customer success analyst: Logins show access activity, but the purchased workflow is barely being used. Those measures answer different questions.

03 • Account director: Then usage volume and adoption of the intended process shouldn't be treated as interchangeable.

04 • Customer success analyst: Exactly. A health score can summarize signals, but it needs definitions that reflect the account's actual purpose.

05 • Account director: Could high stakeholder engagement still make the account healthy even when that workflow use is low?

06 • Customer success analyst: It may be relevant, but we need evidence of that engagement and a transparent interpretation of the signals.

07 • Account director: I'll avoid saying frequent logins prove the customer is achieving the benefit they bought us for.

08 • Customer success analyst: Good. Ask what users are doing and what prevents use of the intended workflow.

09 • Account director: Let's review those questions with the customer before turning the dashboard color into a renewal prediction.

10 • Customer success analyst: Agreed. We'll distinguish measured activity, meaningful adoption, and outcomes rather than compress them into one claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

One power user does not represent the whole team

Separate fictional case: one user completes ninety of a team's hundred workflow runs; no information about the other users' readiness has been reviewed.

01 • Customer success manager: The team recorded one hundred workflow runs, but one power user completed ninety of them.

02 • Customer team lead: So the total shows activity, but it doesn't demonstrate adoption across the whole team.

03 • Customer success manager: Correct. A concentrated usage pattern differs from broad participation, even when the total looks strong.

04 • Customer team lead: Could the other users be inactive because they don't need the workflow as often?

05 • Customer success manager: Possibly. We haven't reviewed their roles or readiness, so low activity isn't automatically a problem.

06 • Customer team lead: Then we should compare expected use by role before deciding who needs additional support.

07 • Customer success manager: Exactly. Stakeholder engagement and user needs provide context that a single activity count cannot supply.

08 • Customer team lead: I'll ask the team about their responsibilities rather than tell everyone to increase usage for the dashboard.

09 • Customer success manager: Good. The health score should support understanding, not encourage activity unrelated to the customer's purpose.

10 • Customer team lead: Let's review the role-based expectations and then agree whether any adoption support is needed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A green score based on stale engagement data

Separate fictional case: a customer health score remains green using an old sponsor-meeting record; the sponsor has since changed and current engagement is unknown.

01 • Customer success analyst: The health score uses an old sponsor-meeting record. Since the sponsor changed, current engagement is unknown.

02 • Account manager: Does green mean the account is healthy now, or that the recorded inputs previously met the scoring rules?

03 • Customer success analyst: The latter. A score reflects its inputs and definitions; it doesn't independently verify the current relationship.

04 • Account manager: Then we should distinguish an unchanged color from confirmed stakeholder engagement with the new sponsor.

05 • Customer success analyst: Exactly. We need a current check before relying on that signal in the account review.

06 • Account manager: Could I simply change the score to red because the sponsor is new?

07 • Customer success analyst: Don't invent an interpretation. Follow our scoring definition and record the missing or outdated input explicitly.

08 • Account manager: I'll request an introduction and clarify the new sponsor's priorities rather than assume dissatisfaction.

09 • Customer success analyst: Good. Then we can update the input using actual evidence of engagement.

10 • Account manager: I'll explain the score's limitation in the meantime so the team doesn't mistake historical data for current confirmation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

An account has many logins but little use of the workflow it purchased the product to improve.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Logins show activity, but they do not tell us whether the intended workflow is being adopted. Let's review the relevant usage and ask the customer about the outcome they are trying to achieve.

Scenario 2 | Automated activity in a usage count

A fictional account dashboard counts 1,000 events, including an unknown number from scheduled automation. Human use of the purchased workflow has not been separated. Explain why the total cannot directly establish user adoption.

Role A: You are the success analyst. Distinguish recorded events from human workflow participation.

Role B: You are the account manager. Ask how to identify the relevant usage before interpreting the health score.

Possible opening: The event total includes automation, so it doesn't yet tell us how many people are using the workflow.

Success checks

- Distinguish events, users, and adoption.
- Keep the automation share explicitly unknown.
- Agree a data-definition check before drawing a health conclusion.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call all events active users.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Support Escalations and Incident Communication

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

A customer issue has a verified workaround but no confirmed permanent-fix date.
A draft update promises a fix tomorrow.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

escalation - Raising an issue to a higher authority or different function because risk, urgency, or decision rights require it.

severity - The seriousness of an event, impact, or loss under stated criteria.

workaround - A temporary alternative that allows a task to continue while the underlying issue remains.

SLA - Service-level agreement defining expected service performance or response commitments.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Compare this wording: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team plans to complete the review.
 - B. The team has completed the review.
 - C. The team is completing the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.
 - B. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - C. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A verified workaround, not tomorrow's permanent fix

The lesson's issue has a verified workaround but no confirmed permanent-fix date; a draft update promises a fix tomorrow.

01 • Customer success manager: The workaround is verified, but the draft promises a permanent fix tomorrow without a confirmed date.

02 • Support escalation lead: That promise needs correction. We can report the workaround's status and the continuing investigation separately.

03 • Customer success manager: What should I tell the customer about progress without making the workaround sound like complete resolution?

04 • Support escalation lead: State that a workaround is available for the verified case and that permanent-fix timing remains unconfirmed.

05 • Customer success manager: Should I describe the issue as lower severity simply because the workaround exists?

06 • Support escalation lead: Use the actual impact and support process. A workaround alone doesn't establish the appropriate severity classification.

07 • Customer success manager: I'll also keep the SLA question separate rather than imply a service agreement guarantees tomorrow's repair.

08 • Support escalation lead: Good. Ask the account owner to confirm the applicable communication commitments from the actual agreement.

09 • Customer success manager: I'll replace the unsupported date with a precise status and confirm the next communication arrangement.

10 • Support escalation lead: I'll supply verified technical changes as they become available, without treating an estimate as a commitment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A fix deployed but not yet verified with the customer

Separate fictional case: engineering deployed a candidate fix for a report-export issue; customer-environment verification has not finished.

01 • Support incident lead: Engineering deployed the candidate fix, but verification in the customer's environment is still pending.

02 • Customer operations lead: Then the issue isn't confirmed resolved for our team, even though deployment is complete?

03 • Support incident lead: Correct. Deployment is a completed action; successful customer verification remains a separate step.

04 • Customer operations lead: Can we resume the affected reporting workflow immediately based on that deployment update?

05 • Support incident lead: Let's follow the agreed verification process and current guidance rather than infer readiness from deployment alone.

06 • Customer operations lead: Understood. I can coordinate the customer-side check once the authorized test arrangement is confirmed.

07 • Support incident lead: Thank you. We'll keep the escalation open for the remaining verification and report any unsuccessful result.

08 • Customer operations lead: Please avoid saying fixed in the subject line while the body says we're still checking.

09 • Support incident lead: Agreed. The status will say candidate fix deployed, customer verification pending, with the next action clearly identified.

10 • Customer operations lead: That gives us an accurate update to share internally without overstating service recovery.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The workaround covers exports, not scheduled delivery

Separate fictional case: a verified workaround allows manual report export; scheduled email delivery remains affected and no permanent-fix date is confirmed.

01 • Customer success manager: Manual export works through the verified workaround, but scheduled email delivery remains affected.

02 • Customer reporting lead: Our team relies on scheduled delivery. The update sounded as though all reporting functionality was restored.

03 • Customer success manager: I should state the boundary clearly: export has a workaround; scheduled delivery still lacks a confirmed resolution.

04 • Customer reporting lead: Could we describe manual export as an option while making its additional effort visible?

05 • Customer success manager: Yes. We shouldn't present the workaround as equivalent to your normal workflow or hide the remaining impact.

06 • Customer reporting lead: Do you have a verified date for the permanent fix, or only an investigation status?

07 • Customer success manager: Only the investigation status. I won't promise a date the support team hasn't confirmed.

08 • Customer reporting lead: Then include the affected scheduled-delivery function when you update the escalation and customer impact.

09 • Customer success manager: I will. I'll also confirm our communication arrangement separately from the unresolved repair timing.

10 • Customer reporting lead: Thank you. A scoped workaround update is useful, provided the unresolved part of our workflow stays visible.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Support Escalations and Incident Communication

A customer issue has a verified workaround but no confirmed permanent-fix date. A draft update promises a fix tomorrow.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: We have a verified workaround, but the permanent-fix date is not confirmed. I'll explain the workaround and state the next update time without promising an unverified resolution date.

Scenario 2 | A reported workaround failure in a second configuration

A fictional workaround was verified in configuration A. The customer reports it did not work in configuration B, and that second report has not been reproduced. Give a scoped escalation update.

Role A: You are the support lead. Separate the verified A result from the reported B failure.

Role B: You are the customer success manager. Ask for the next authorized verification and what can be communicated now.

Possible opening: The workaround is verified in configuration A; the reported failure in B still needs investigation.

Success checks

- State the tested configuration and limit the claim accordingly.
- Keep the second report visible without calling its cause confirmed.
- Agree the next verification and customer communication step.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to say the workaround is universally reliable based on the first test.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

QBRs and Business Outcomes

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A business review claims a large return on investment using estimated time savings that the customer has not validated.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

QBR - Quarterly business review: a periodic customer discussion of results, priorities, and next steps.

business outcome - A result the organization wants to achieve through its work.

ROI - Return on investment: a measure comparing a defined net benefit with investment cost; state the calculation and assumptions.

executive sponsor - A senior person who supports an initiative and helps resolve major organizational issues.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Estimated savings do not establish validated ROI

The lesson's business review claims substantial return on investment from estimated time savings the customer has not validated.

01 • Customer success manager: The QBR draft claims a large return on investment, but its time-saving estimates haven't been validated by your team.

02 • Customer executive sponsor: Then we shouldn't present the figure as a measured business outcome. What evidence does it actually reflect?

03 • Customer success manager: It reflects assumptions about time saved, not a confirmed customer measurement of those savings.

04 • Customer executive sponsor: Could we keep the estimate if its assumptions and limitations are clearly visible?

05 • Customer success manager: We can discuss it as an estimate, subject to the review's purpose, without labeling it realized ROI.

06 • Customer executive sponsor: Please explain ROI as return on investment and identify which costs the calculation includes or leaves unresolved.

07 • Customer success manager: Agreed. We should not convert an unverified time estimate into a financial claim without that context.

08 • Customer executive sponsor: Let's review the measurement approach before using the figure in an executive decision.

09 • Customer success manager: I'll distinguish observed information, estimated savings, and missing cost inputs in the quarterly business review.

10 • Customer executive sponsor: That lets us discuss potential value without treating an unvalidated model as an achieved result.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A pilot outcome outside the full account scope

Separate fictional case: a pilot team reduced measured report preparation from four hours to three; no other teams have been measured.

01 • Customer account director: The pilot team reduced report preparation from four hours to three. Can the QBR claim this across the account?

02 • Customer analytics lead: Only the pilot team was measured. We don't have evidence that other teams achieved the same change.

03 • Customer account director: Then the observed business outcome is limited to that team's measured reporting task.

04 • Customer analytics lead: Correct. We should also preserve the measurement conditions rather than imply every report takes one hour less.

05 • Customer account director: Could we show an account-wide projection as a separate scenario rather than a realized saving?

06 • Customer analytics lead: Only with its assumptions explicit and suitable review. It must not look like measured account performance.

07 • Customer account director: I'll lead with the actual pilot result and label broader potential as untested.

08 • Customer analytics lead: Good. The executive sponsor needs to know which claim is observation and which is extrapolation.

09 • Customer account director: Let's agree what additional team evidence would support a wider business-outcome discussion.

10 • Customer analytics lead: I'll identify the measurement gaps before we put any account-wide ROI claim into the readout.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Time released is not automatically payroll saved

Separate fictional case: a customer validates reduced time on a reporting task but has not measured any reduction in payroll or other expenditure.

01 • Customer success director: Your team validated less time spent on reporting. Should the QBR translate that directly into payroll savings?

02 • Customer finance lead: No. We haven't measured lower payroll or other expenditure, so that would overstate the financial outcome.

03 • Customer success director: Then released time is the observed benefit, while an actual cash saving remains unestablished.

04 • Customer finance lead: Exactly. Staff may use that time for other work, but we haven't measured that use either.

05 • Customer success director: I'll avoid claiming either reduced spending or additional output without evidence for those next steps.

06 • Customer finance lead: Good. A monetary scenario would need clear assumptions and costs, separate from the validated time result.

07 • Customer success director: Would you review the wording before we present it to the executive sponsor?

08 • Customer finance lead: Yes. Keep the measured task, time boundary, and unconfirmed financial interpretation visible.

09 • Customer success director: I'll describe the business outcome as reduced reporting time, with no claim of realized payroll savings.

10 • Customer finance lead: That is accurate and still meaningful. We can discuss any further value analysis as a separate next step.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | QBRs and Business Outcomes

A business review claims a large return on investment using estimated time savings that the customer has not validated.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The return estimate depends on unverified time-saving assumptions. Let's review those assumptions with the customer and label the result as an estimate rather than a demonstrated outcome.

Scenario 2 | The baseline came from a different team

A fictional business review compares the current team's two-hour task with another team's old five-hour estimate. The tasks and measurement methods have not been matched. Discuss whether the comparison supports a customer saving claim.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Identify the unmatched baseline and avoid claiming a three-hour achieved saving.

Role B: You are the customer's analytics lead. Ask for comparable task definitions and measurement evidence.

Possible opening: The five-hour baseline came from another team, so it doesn't yet establish what this team saved.

Success checks

- State the baseline mismatch explicitly.
- Distinguish a numerical difference from a validated improvement.
- Agree a like-for-like measurement before making an outcome claim.

Add a complication: An executive wants the larger saving kept because it looks impressive.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Renewals and Churn Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

An account renews in six weeks. The main contact has changed, and the team has not confirmed current priorities.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

renewal - Continuation of a policy, contract, or subscription for a further period.

churn risk - The possibility that a customer will stop using or renewing a service.

commercial term - A business condition of an agreement, such as price, quantity, or payment timing.

value gap - The difference between the value a customer expects and the value they experience.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - B. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - C. Send it no later than Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - B. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - C. Could you confirm that the review is important?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Six weeks to renewal, new priorities unknown

The lesson's renewal is six weeks away; the main contact has changed and current customer priorities are unconfirmed.

01 • Customer success manager: Your renewal is six weeks away. Could we arrange a discussion with the new owner to confirm current priorities?

02 • Customer account coordinator: Yes. The main contact changed, and the previous success plan may not reflect the new owner's needs.

03 • Customer success manager: Please identify who can discuss the business priorities and who handles the commercial terms.

04 • Customer account coordinator: I'll check those roles rather than assume the new contact controls both decisions.

05 • Customer success manager: Thank you. We need to understand any value gap before discussing a renewal proposal as though nothing changed.

06 • Customer account coordinator: Does the contact change mean you consider us likely to leave, even without hearing our current plans?

07 • Customer success manager: No. It creates a need for clarification, not proof of churn. Our assessment should reflect actual evidence.

08 • Customer account coordinator: I'll seek an appropriate meeting time and tell you who can attend.

09 • Customer success manager: I'll bring the existing goals and ask what remains relevant, without assuming renewed commitment.

10 • Customer account coordinator: That will give the new owner a practical conversation rather than a request to endorse the old plan unchanged.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A renewal conversation needs the service owner

Separate fictional case: a procurement contact requests renewal pricing but has no information about whether the service team still uses the purchased workflow.

01 • Renewal manager: Could we involve the service owner before finalizing the renewal discussion? Current workflow use and priorities remain unclear.

02 • Customer procurement officer: I can request pricing, but I don't know whether the service team still needs the same scope.

03 • Renewal manager: Exactly. Commercial terms need to reflect the actual requirement rather than simply repeat last year's order.

04 • Customer procurement officer: Would you like me to ask the service owner for current use cases and any unmet needs?

05 • Renewal manager: Yes. That helps clarify a possible value gap without assuming dissatisfaction or expansion needs.

06 • Customer procurement officer: I can't promise their availability today, but I can ask and return with a realistic meeting option.

07 • Renewal manager: Thank you. Please also confirm who will approve any scope change, so the review reaches the right people.

08 • Customer procurement officer: I'll clarify that separately from my role coordinating the quote.

09 • Renewal manager: I'll keep the renewal status factual and avoid treating a pricing request as acceptance of the same service package.

10 • Customer procurement officer: Agreed. Let's establish the requirement first, then discuss the appropriate commercial proposal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A competitor inquiry is a clarification opportunity

Separate fictional case: a customer mentions reviewing another supplier, but has not stated an intention to cancel or explained the comparison criteria.

01 • Customer success manager: You mentioned reviewing another supplier. Could we discuss which needs or gaps you want the comparison to address?

02 • Customer service director: We are exploring options, not announcing cancellation. We haven't shared our criteria with you yet.

03 • Customer success manager: Thank you for clarifying. I won't record the inquiry as a confirmed decision to leave.

04 • Customer service director: Could we focus on our current workflow concerns before discussing discounts or commercial terms?

05 • Customer success manager: Absolutely. Please identify the main value gap and who should join a focused review.

06 • Customer service director: I'll ask the workflow owner to bring specific examples and confirm a suitable time.

07 • Customer success manager: Good. We can distinguish issues we can investigate from outcomes we cannot promise.

08 • Customer service director: I appreciate that. We don't need an immediate assurance that every requirement will be satisfied.

09 • Customer success manager: I'll arrange the review and keep churn risk as an assessment with evidence, not a prediction presented as fact.

10 • Customer service director: Let's use the discussion to clarify our priorities before either side assumes the renewal outcome.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Renewals and Churn Risk

An account renews in six weeks. The main contact has changed, and the team has not confirmed current priorities.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could we arrange a review with the current decision makers to confirm priorities and unresolved issues? That will help us understand the renewal discussion before assuming the previous plan still fits.

Scenario 2 | A renewal reminder sent to the departed contact

A fictional renewal reminder went to a former employee. The commercial review is still pending, and the new responsible contact has not been identified. Request the appropriate owner and a realistic response arrangement.

Role A: You are the renewal coordinator. Explain the contact gap and request an authorized replacement contact.

Role B: You are the customer's operations administrator. Confirm that the former employee has left and identify whom you must ask about ownership.

Possible opening: Our reminder reached the former contact; could you help identify who now coordinates the renewal review?

Success checks

- Distinguish an outdated contact from a cancellation decision.
- Request the correct owner and purpose-specific meeting.
- Agree a follow-up without inventing approval authority or renewal intent.

Add a complication: A colleague treats the lack of reply as proof that the customer intends to cancel.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Expansion and Upsell Ethics

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A customer is considering more licenses while many existing users have not completed onboarding.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

upsell - Offering a customer a higher-value version or additional paid capability.

expansion - An increase in the scope or size of a customer relationship or business activity.

use case - A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

readiness - The degree to which required conditions for an activity have been met.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Compare this wording: This option is more better.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

More licenses or better use of existing capacity?

The lesson's customer considers more licenses while many current users have not completed onboarding.

01 • Customer account lead: We are considering more licenses. Could expansion help us get more value from the service?

02 • Customer success manager: Possibly, but many current users haven't completed onboarding. We should compare expansion with improving readiness first.

03 • Customer account lead: I don't want an upsell recommendation that assumes every new license will immediately produce useful activity.

04 • Customer success manager: Agreed. Both options need the same use-case and readiness criteria, including who will use the service and why.

05 • Customer account lead: Completing onboarding may improve use of existing capacity, while expansion could address a genuinely new requirement.

06 • Customer success manager: Exactly. We need to establish that requirement rather than infer it from interest in more licenses.

07 • Customer account lead: Please help us review the current users and proposed new group before quoting a broader rollout.

08 • Customer success manager: I will. We'll make the support effort and unresolved readiness questions visible for each option.

09 • Customer account lead: Then we can choose a useful next step without treating a purchase itself as evidence of adoption.

10 • Customer success manager: That is the aim: compare the actual needs and tradeoffs before recommending expansion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A new department pilot or an account-wide add-on

Separate fictional case: a customer asks about an add-on for five departments, but only one department has described a concrete use case; requirements elsewhere are unknown.

01 • Customer transformation lead: Could we add the module for all five departments, or should we start with the one defined use case?

02 • Customer success director: Let's compare a bounded pilot with wider expansion. Only one department's requirement is currently clear.

03 • Customer transformation lead: The wider purchase might simplify administration, but it could include departments whose needs we haven't assessed.

04 • Customer success director: Correct. A pilot limits initial scope while leaving later readiness and fit to be reviewed.

05 • Customer transformation lead: Would you guarantee that a successful pilot means the module fits the other four departments?

06 • Customer success director: No. Their workflows may differ; we need evidence rather than transferring the first department's result automatically.

07 • Customer transformation lead: Then compare support needs, scope, and decision points for both options without assuming universal use.

08 • Customer success director: Agreed. I'll also keep any commercial terms subject to the appropriate proposal and review.

09 • Customer transformation lead: I'll ask the other department owners to clarify their requirements before we commit them to an expansion.

10 • Customer success director: That will give us a fairer basis for a recommendation than account-wide interest alone.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An advanced feature versus a simpler workflow change

Separate fictional case: a customer seeks faster approval handling; a paid advanced module is available, but a change to its existing workflow might help and neither option has been tested.

01 • Customer operations manager: Should we buy the advanced module to speed up approvals, or review our existing workflow first?

02 • Customer success consultant: We should compare both against the same need. Neither option has been tested in your process.

03 • Customer operations manager: The module adds capability, while a workflow change might use what we already have.

04 • Customer success consultant: Yes. But we shouldn't claim either will reduce approval time without understanding the current obstacle.

05 • Customer operations manager: Could you include implementation effort and training readiness, not just the additional subscription price?

06 • Customer success consultant: Certainly. Those affect whether an expansion is useful, even if the feature appears attractive.

07 • Customer operations manager: I would prefer a proportionate assessment before an upsell proposal becomes the default answer.

08 • Customer success consultant: Agreed. Let's clarify the bottleneck and examine what each route requires and leaves unresolved.

09 • Customer operations manager: I'll involve the approval owner so the comparison reflects the actual use case.

10 • Customer success consultant: Then we can recommend a next step based on fit and readiness rather than on purchasing more capability.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Expansion and Upsell Ethics

A customer is considering more licenses while many existing users have not completed onboarding.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: Additional licenses may be useful, but adoption of the current ones is still incomplete. Let's compare expansion with improving onboarding against the customer's immediate goals before recommending the next purchase.

Scenario 2 | Seasonal demand or permanent license expansion

A fictional customer expects a short busy period but has not confirmed how many additional users need access or for how long. Existing license flexibility is unreviewed. Compare permanent expansion with checking current arrangements first.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Ask for duration and user requirements and explain the comparison criteria.

Role B: You are the customer team lead. Describe the uncertainty and seek a proportionate option without assuming temporary terms exist.

Possible opening: Before discussing permanent expansion, let's confirm the additional users, duration, and flexibility in your current arrangement.

Success checks

- Keep user count and duration explicitly unconfirmed.
- Compare scope and readiness without inventing available contract options.
- Agree a requirements and terms check before recommending expansion.

Add a complication: A salesperson presents permanent licenses as the only option without checking the current terms.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Product Feedback and Feature Requests

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A customer asks for a specific feature, but the product team needs to understand the underlying workflow and current obstacle.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

feature request - A proposal for new or changed product functionality.

roadmap - A plan showing intended product or organizational direction over time, with varying levels of commitment.

workaround - A temporary alternative that allows a task to continue while the underlying issue remains.

product feedback - Information from users or stakeholders about how a product meets their needs.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - B. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - C. Could you confirm when starts the review?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - B. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - C. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The requested feature is not yet the requirement

Separate fictional case aligned with the lesson: a reporting coordinator requests red warning badges because they open each invoice row to check approval before a Friday export. Individual approvals must remain, and supported display alternatives have not been checked.

01 • Customer success manager: You requested red warning badges. Which problem would those badges solve before your Friday export?

02 • Customer reporting coordinator: I open each invoice row to check approval. I need to find unapproved items without repeating that navigation.

03 • Customer success manager: So the obstacle is seeing approval status in the list, not completing the export itself?

04 • Customer reporting coordinator: Correct. The export works. We still need every invoice approved individually before including it.

05 • Customer success manager: Would a clear status label meet the need, or is the red color itself essential?

06 • Customer reporting coordinator: A clear label could work. Red was my suggested solution, not a requirement.

07 • Customer success manager: Then I will record visible approval status as the requirement, with individual review preserved.

08 • Customer reporting coordinator: Yes. Can you check existing display options before sending a new feature request?

09 • Customer success manager: I will check supported options. Neither a workaround nor a roadmap commitment is confirmed yet.

10 • Customer reporting coordinator: Understood. Please confirm what is available, and keep any proposed feature timing explicitly open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A bulk button request with an approval constraint

Separate fictional case: a customer requests bulk approval, but says each item currently requires a separate review; the intended boundary of the proposed shortcut is unclear.

01 • Product liaison: You requested a bulk approval button. Which part should become faster while the individual review requirement remains?

02 • Customer operations lead: We still need separate review. I may be asking to reduce repeated navigation rather than approve everything together.

03 • Product liaison: That's an important distinction. Could you describe the sequence after you finish reviewing one item?

04 • Customer operations lead: I can show the current workflow in a sanitized example. I don't want to remove our review responsibility.

05 • Product liaison: Then the feature request should identify the navigation obstacle instead of imply a change to your approval controls.

06 • Customer operations lead: Would that make it a different product-feedback item rather than simply a renamed bulk-approval request?

07 • Product liaison: It may change the requirement significantly. We'll clarify it before the product team assesses possible solutions.

08 • Customer operations lead: Please don't promise a roadmap date based on the initial button description.

09 • Product liaison: Agreed. I'll record the reviewed requirement and keep implementation choices and timing unconfirmed.

10 • Customer operations lead: I'll provide the example and confirm which review steps must remain separate.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An export request with an unknown recipient need

Separate fictional case: a customer asks for a new export format because an external reviewer cannot use the current file; the reviewer's required structure is unknown.

01 • Customer success specialist: Could you clarify what the external reviewer needs that the current export doesn't provide?

02 • Customer reporting owner: They said the file wasn't usable, but we haven't obtained the required structure or an example.

03 • Customer success specialist: Then we should clarify that before requesting a new format based on our guess.

04 • Customer reporting owner: Could the problem be a missing field rather than the file type itself?

05 • Customer success specialist: Possibly. We need the actual obstacle, including whether it concerns content, structure, or access.

06 • Customer reporting owner: I'll ask for a non-sensitive sample specification rather than forward our full reporting file unnecessarily.

07 • Customer success specialist: Good. That will help product assess the feature request and any existing supported alternative.

08 • Customer reporting owner: Should I tell the reviewer that your roadmap will include their preferred format?

09 • Customer success specialist: No. We can commit to reviewing the clarified feedback, not to building an unassessed feature.

10 • Customer reporting owner: Understood. I'll obtain the requirement and keep any solution or delivery date open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Product Feedback and Feature Requests

A customer asks for a specific feature, but the product team needs to understand the underlying workflow and current obstacle.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: What task are you trying to complete, and what prevents you from doing it today? I'll record the workflow and impact so the product team can evaluate the request without treating a proposed feature as the only solution.

Scenario 2 | A mobile request that may concern notifications

A fictional customer asks for a mobile app but explains only that field staff miss updates while away from desks. Their devices, access constraints, and notification needs are unknown. Clarify the need before discussing roadmap options.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Ask what staff need to notice or do away from their desks.

Role B: You are the customer's field operations lead. Explain what is known and identify which user details you must gather.

Possible opening: When you request a mobile app, which update or action do field staff need while away from their desks?

Success checks

- Separate the proposed app from the underlying workflow need.
- Request device and access context without guessing it.
- Keep roadmap inclusion and timing explicitly uncommitted.

Add a complication: The customer asks for a launch date before the workflow is clarified.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

A frustrated customer says a feature was promised for this month. The record contains an estimate, not a confirmed commitment.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

boundary - A limit on acceptable conduct, responsibility, access, or scope.

executive escalation - Referring an unresolved issue to senior leadership for attention or a decision.

commitment - An explicit promise or accepted responsibility to do something.

expectation setting - Clarifying what can be delivered, under which conditions, and by when.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Compare this wording: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
 - B. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
 - C. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.
 - B. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.
 - C. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An estimate was heard as a commitment

The lesson's frustrated customer believes a feature was promised this month; the record contains an estimate rather than a confirmed commitment.

01 • Customer department head: We were told the feature would arrive this month. We planned our work around that promise.

02 • Customer success manager: I understand why you're frustrated. Our record shows an estimate, but we did not make that distinction clear enough.

03 • Customer department head: Are you saying the misunderstanding is ours because we relied on what your team said?

04 • Customer success manager: No. We need to own the unclear expectation setting. I cannot honestly restate the estimate as a confirmed commitment.

05 • Customer department head: Then can an executive escalation guarantee the date we expected?

06 • Customer success manager: It can bring the concern to the appropriate leaders, but it doesn't itself create a delivery guarantee.

07 • Customer department head: I need a clear account of what is known and what we should stop assuming.

08 • Customer success manager: I'll confirm the current reviewed status and explain any supported alternatives, without inventing a release date.

09 • Customer department head: Please correct the expectation in writing after this call so our planning team has the same information.

10 • Customer success manager: I will. The correction will acknowledge the ambiguity and clearly separate estimates from confirmed commitments.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An informal chat sounded like round-the-clock support

Separate fictional case: an account manager's casual message said contact me anytime; the customer interpreted it as a new round-the-clock response commitment, which is not recorded.

01 • Customer operations lead: Your message said contact me anytime. We understood that as a promise of immediate support outside normal hours.

02 • Customer success manager: My wording was too broad. It did not establish a new commitment; I should have explained the support route.

03 • Customer operations lead: We need to know where to go with an urgent issue, not just hear that the wording was informal.

04 • Customer success manager: Agreed. I'll confirm the applicable support channel and response terms from your actual arrangement.

05 • Customer operations lead: Can you personally promise to answer immediately next time while that clarification is underway?

06 • Customer success manager: I can't promise availability I cannot guarantee. That would repeat the expectation-setting problem.

07 • Customer operations lead: Then make the boundary clear without making us feel the service concern is being dismissed.

08 • Customer success manager: I will. I'll acknowledge the concern, explain the confirmed route, and distinguish my account role from support commitments.

09 • Customer operations lead: Please send the clarified arrangement so our shift leads don't rely on the casual message.

10 • Customer success manager: After verification, I'll confirm only coverage and response times the agreement establishes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A review commitment mistaken for a feature commitment

Separate fictional case: a success manager promised to take a request to product; the customer now says that meant product had agreed to build it.

01 • Customer program manager: You promised to take our request forward. We understood that product had agreed to build the feature.

02 • Customer success manager: I should have been clearer: I committed to submitting it for review, not to a development decision.

03 • Customer program manager: That distinction wasn't obvious to us. We have been telling users it is coming.

04 • Customer success manager: I'm sorry our expectation setting allowed that impression. We need to correct it before it spreads further.

05 • Customer program manager: Can you now turn it into a commitment through an executive escalation?

06 • Customer success manager: I can raise the concern appropriately, but escalation doesn't authorize me to promise scope or timing.

07 • Customer program manager: Then please explain exactly what status you can verify and what remains undecided.

08 • Customer success manager: I'll confirm the review status with product and keep the build decision separate from the submission action.

09 • Customer program manager: We can correct our user message once we have that clear account, even if the answer remains open.

10 • Customer success manager: I'll provide the correction and verified status, without describing review as acceptance or a roadmap guarantee.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

A frustrated customer says a feature was promised for this month. The record contains an estimate, not a confirmed commitment.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: I understand why you expected it this month. The earlier wording did not clearly distinguish an estimate from a commitment. I'll clarify the current status and discuss the available options with the responsible team.

Scenario 2 | A request for unlimited custom help

A fictional customer interpreted an offer to help with setup as unlimited custom configuration work. No expanded service scope was agreed. The customer has three requested changes, but their effort and support coverage have not been reviewed. Repair expectations and set a respectful boundary.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Acknowledge the broad wording and offer a scoped review of the requests.

Role B: You are the customer administrator. Explain the expectation and ask what can genuinely be assessed next.

Possible opening: Our offer to help with setup was too broad; we need to clarify which work is covered before making further commitments.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the unclear expectation without blaming the customer.
- Keep unreviewed effort and coverage explicitly open.
- Agree a scoped review rather than an unlimited service promise.

Add a complication: The customer asks you to promise all three changes immediately as an apology.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: A - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

B: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

C: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

Check 2: C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

B: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

C: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

Model response: What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

B: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

C: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

Check 2: B - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

B: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

C: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

Model response: Logins show activity, but they do not tell us whether the intended workflow is being adopted. Let's review the relevant usage and ask the customer about the outcome they are trying to achieve.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Support Escalations and Incident Communication

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: B - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

B: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

C: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

Check 2: A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

B: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

C: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

Model response: We have a verified workaround, but the permanent-fix date is not confirmed. I'll explain the workaround and state the next update time without promising an unverified resolution date.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | QBRs and Business Outcomes

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: The return estimate depends on unverified time-saving assumptions. Let's review those assumptions with the customer and label the result as an estimate rather than a demonstrated outcome.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Renewals and Churn Risk

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: C - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

B: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

C: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

Check 2: B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

B: The requested action and information are explicit.

C: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

Model response: Could we arrange a review with the current decision makers to confirm priorities and unresolved issues? That will help us understand the renewal discussion before assuming the previous plan still fits.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Expansion and Upsell Ethics

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: Additional licenses may be useful, but adoption of the current ones is still incomplete. Let's compare expansion with improving onboarding against the customer's immediate goals before recommending the next purchase.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Product Feedback and Feature Requests

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: A - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

B: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

C: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

Check 2: C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

B: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

C: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

Model response: What task are you trying to complete, and what prevents you from doing it today? I'll record the workflow and impact so the product team can evaluate the request without treating a proposed feature as the only solution.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: C - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

B: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

C: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

Check 2: B - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

B: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

C: The reader still lacks the information they need.

Model response: I understand why you expected it this month. The earlier wording did not clearly distinguish an estimate from a commitment. I'll clarify the current status and discuss the available options with the responsible team.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Customer Success English

Professional audience: customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Original fictional case: A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: onboarding: The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively. / go-live: The point at which a system or service begins its intended operational use. / implementation: Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation. / customer owner: The person on the customer's side responsible for coordinating an agreed activity.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level